

impressed by the fact that you have a 10-second printer—it's the quality of print that matters most.

Smudged and faded printouts are a definite no-no for business prints, and we checked the printers for the quality of text print, using our point size document.

The first printer we tested was the Canon LBP 2900. The quality of print was simply amazing, with a crisp, bright look, and even the smallest of point sizes perfectly legible. The Samsungs (ML1710P and ML1520P) and Lexmark's E230 matched the Canon letter for letter, with good quality prints.

Judging by the quality of prints, we felt that the Lexmark focussed more on quality than on speed. Throughout our quality tests, the Lexmark took the Canon 2900 head-on, and even edged ahead a few times.

The printer that disappointed us, throughout was the WeP 1600. It spat out some dull-looking prints. The Canon LBP 3200 was not much better, and seemed to have sacrificed greatly on quality to gain speed, and ended up second last in the text printout quality test.

Another point to note here is that the Samsung printers had only 300 and 600 dpi resolutions, while the others had 1,200 dpi as their best. Yet the Samsungs held their own...

All this testing showed us that the Canon LBP 2900 was the fastest and among the best in terms of the quality. So, if black and white text printouts are all you need, buy this one now!

Getting back to the tests, the difference in resolutions would become clearer if we used image- or graph-heavy documents, and so, obviously, we did a quality check of our combi docs as well. We tested in both, Normal and Best modes and the results were more or less identical. This proved the very impressive quality of the printers, even in Normal mode.

The clear winner, in terms of performance, was the Canon LBP 2900. This printer sacrifices marginally on speed, but gains an incredible advantage in terms of quality.

The Xerox 3116 had the worst results, and the Samsung ML1520P matched it smudge for smudge! In both cases, the reverse document, with white text on a purely black background, was nowhere close to legible.

The Samsungs faltered because of the 600 dpi



Canon LBP 2900

limitation, and Xerox was a disappointment in terms of scores.

There were surprises to come, especially when we saw the WeP 1600 tying for second place with the Samsung ML1710P.

Although this printer could print at the same resolution as the 1520P, it gave us our best scores on the white text on a black background box and just about edged out the others in the resolution of the pie-chart test. Here, it was joined by Xerox, which scored the same.

We were quite sure that the 3200 would win all speed tests, but once we were through with the quality tests, everything went haywire...

The final tests also included a warranty check. A long warranty period with on-site warranty is naturally preferred. In terms of number of years, all except Canon and Lexmark provided a 3-year warranty, and all, except WeP and Xerox, provided on-site warranty.

At 100, Samsung in India has a fairly large number of service centres, WeP has 190. Xerox had only 100 service centres, and was beaten to fourth place by Canon with 130.

Coming in last was Lexmark, which offers only a 1-year on-site warranty, and just 34 service centres across the country for support.

Now the biggest cost you will incur (apart from buying the printer) will be the cost of printing the pages. A few manufacturers will give you the printer with a starter toner that has less capacity than the ones you would buy in the market. When it runs out, you will have to buy a new one. So we did a per page cost comparison.

We noticed that only WeP and Xerox were shipping their printers with starter toners, which can print about 1,200 and 1,000 pages respectively. A fresh toner can print roughly 3,000 pages—almost thrice as much.

The Canon LBP 2900 was the least productive, with a toner life of 2,000 pages. Lexmark offered 2,500, and all the others promised a toner life of about 3,000 pages.

In terms of cost per page, the Canon LBP 3200 reigned at only Rs 1.16 a page. The Xerox 3116 came in second costing Rs 1.25 per page, while a Lexmark printer would set you back by Rs 1.3 per print. A Samsung, though, will cost you all of Rs 1.49 per page.



Lexmark E230